

Demon Possession Of Unbelievers

doc-demon-possession-of-unbelievers

Demonology · Possession · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.787
confidence high

Statement under examination

Unbelievers can be subject to demonic possession (full inhabitation), as the Gospels and Acts repeatedly attest.

In plain language

The Greek verb behind these scenes is 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai), usually rendered 'to be demonized'. It occurs thirteen times in the New Testament, all in the Gospels, and it is always used of people who are not followers of Jesus. The reading is not just about a label on those people. The surrounding grammar is concretely spatial. Demons are said to enter into the person, using 'into' (eis) plus the accusative (the direct-object grammatical form), as when Luke writes that many demons entered into the Gerasene man. They are said to come out from the person, using 'from' (apo) or 'out of' (ek) plus the genitive (the 'from/of' grammatical form), as when Jesus tells the spirit to come out of the man and never enter into him again. The man can be described as in an unclean spirit (en pneumati akathartō) or as having an unclean spirit (ekhōn pneuma akatharton). The spirit can speak through the man's mouth in the first person, as when Legion answers Jesus, and the spirit can act through the man with more than human strength, as when the man in Acts overpowers seven exorcists. In Matthew the cleared person is even pictured as a house in which the spirit takes up residence (katoikei). Across Mark, Matthew, Luke, and Acts the vocabulary is the same. The proposition has one honest limit. The verb itself does not carry a degree word. It says demonized, not the proportion. So the parenthetical 'full inhabitation' in the question is an added description rather than something the word measures on its own. There is also a small group of edge texts where covenant members are pressured by Satan, such as the bent woman Satan had bound, or Ananias whose heart Satan filled. Those use different verbs, binding (deō) and filling (plēroō), not the entering and exiting verbs used of the demonized. So the language reserved for indwelling continues to land on those outside true discipleship. What the words plainly show is that people who are not believers are pictured as inhabited and controlled by unclean spirits that can be commanded out.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0169	ἀκάθαρτος	akathartos	unclean	32
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthrōpos	a human	567
G1139	δαιμονίζομαι	daimonizomai	be demonised	13
G1140	δαιμόνιον	daimonion	demon	63
G1525	εἰσερχομαι	eiserchomai	to enter	194
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1544	ἐκβάλλω	ekballō	to expel	82
G1722	ἐν	en	in/on/among	

G1831	ἐξέρχομαι	exerchomai	to go out	224
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	765
G3686	ὄνομα	onoma	name	
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4183	πολλοί	polus	much	
G4436	πύθων	pythōn	divining spirit	1

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The verb 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai, G1139) occurs 13 times, all in the Gospels, and is uniformly predicated of persons who are not disciples of Jesus. The grammar of these scenes is concretely spatial. Demons are said to 'enter into the man' (eiserchomai eis auton, Luke 8:30) and to 'come out from the man' (exerchomai apo or ek tou anthropou, Mark 1:26, Mark 5:8, Luke 8:33, Matthew 12:43, Acts 16:18). Jesus also says, 'never enter into him again' (mēketi eiselthēs eis auton, Mark 9:25), and the cleared house can be re-inhabited and 'dwelt in' (katoikei ekei, Matthew 12:45). The man can be described as 'having an unclean spirit' (ekhōn pneuma akatharton, Mark 1:23, Acts 19:13), and in Acts 19:16 the spirit acts through the host with superhuman force. The lexical pattern across multiple authors and scenes pictures unbelieving or non-disciple persons as indwelt and controlled by spirits that can be expelled by command.

Scripture

Mark.1.23 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G4151 πνεῦμα, G0169 ἀκάθαρτος

Force. A man in the synagogue is described as 'a man in an unclean spirit' (anthrōpos en pneumati akathartō). The preposition 'in' (en) plus the dative (the 'to/in/with' grammatical form) pictures the spirit as the medium or sphere in which the person now is, marking covert inhabitation rather than mere external proximity.

Mark.1.26 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1831 ἐξέρχομαι

Force. After Jesus rebukes the spirit, the spirit 'came out of him' (exēlthen ex autou). The verb 'to come out' (exerchomai) with 'out of' (ek) and the genitive (the 'from/of' grammatical form) person makes the host the spatial origin of departure, which presupposes the spirit was located inside the man.

Mark.5.2 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G0169 ἀκάθαρτος

Force. A man with an unclean spirit, 'a man in an unclean spirit' (anthrōpos en pneumati akathartō), meets Jesus. The same 'in' (en) plus dative (the 'to/in/with' grammatical form) construction as Mark 1:23 locates the spirit as resident with and operative through the person, and the man is portrayed as an afflicted human, not as a disciple.

Mark.5.8 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1831 ἐξέρχομαι, G0169 ἀκάθαρτος

Force. Jesus commands 'come out of the man, you unclean spirit' (Exelthe to pneuma to akatharton ek tou anthropou). The 'out of' (ek) plus the genitive (the 'from/of' grammatical form) of the host treats the man as the container from which the spirit must depart, which forecloses a merely external oppression reading.

Mark.5.9 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3686 ὄνομα, G4183 πολλοί

Force. The spirit answers 'my name is Legion, for we are many' (Legiōn onoma moi, hoti polloi esmen). The first person speech through the man's mouth, and the self-naming, are lexical markers of inhabitation and operative control, not of an outside influence.

Mark.5.15 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1139 δαιμονίζομαι

Force. The healed man is named 'the one who had been demonized' (ton daimonizomenon), now sitting clothed and 'sound of mind' (sōphronounta). The participle (a verb acting like an adjective) marks his prior demonized state, and the restoration of soundness implies the demon had previously dominated his faculties.

Mark.9.25 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1831 ἐξέρχομαι, G1525 εἰσέρχομαι

Force. Jesus commands the spirit 'come out of him and never enter into him again' (exelthe ex autou kai mēketi eiselthēs eis auton). The paired exit and re-entry verbs with 'out of' (ek) and 'into' (eis) plus the person make the man explicitly the spatial location of the spirit, and forbid future re-occupation.

Matt.8.28 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1139 δαιμονίζομαι

Force. Two 'demonized men' (daimonizomenoi) meet Jesus from the tombs in the country of the Gadarenes. The participial form (a verb acting like an adjective) again marks an attested state of being demonized rather than a transient feeling, and the men are local sufferers, not followers of Jesus.

Matt.12.22 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1139 δαιμονίζομαι

Force. A blind and mute man is brought to Jesus as 'demonized' (daimonizomenos), and the affliction is bound up with the demon so that healing the man casts out the demon. The man is an ordinary sufferer, not a disciple, and the demon is the cause of his disability.

Matt.12.28 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1544 ἐκβάλλω, G1140 δαιμόνιον

Force. Jesus speaks of 'casting out the demons' (ekballō ta daimonia) by the Spirit of God. The verb 'to throw or drive out' (ekballō) presupposes the demon occupied the person, so that deliverance is an expulsion from within rather than a removal of an external pressure.

Matt.12.43 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0169 ἀκάθαρτος, G1831 ἐξέρχομαι, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Force. When the unclean spirit 'goes out from the man' (exelthē apo tou anthrōpou), it wanders. The 'from' (apo) plus genitive (the 'from/of' grammatical form) of the person treats the man as the prior dwelling place. The same vocabulary as Mark 5:8 is used by another author, showing the pattern is not local to one writer.

Matt.12.45 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1525 εἰσέρχομαι

Force. The spirit returns with seven others and 'having entered, takes up residence there' (eiselthonta katoikei ekei). The verb 'to dwell, take up residence' (katoikeō) is the standard verb for dwelling in a house. The image of the man as an inhabited dwelling is explicit and lexically forced.

Luke.8.30 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1525 εἰσέρχομαι, G1140 δαίμόνιον

Force. Luke's parallel to Mark 5 adds the explicit grammar 'many demons had entered into him' (eisēlthen daimonia polla eis auton). 'To enter' (eiserchomai) plus 'into' (eis) plus the accusative (the direct-object grammatical form) person is the strongest available Greek construction for an agent entering a container.

Luke.8.33 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1831 ἐξέρχομαι, G1525 εἰσέρχομαι

Force. The demons 'having come out from the man, entered into the pigs' (exelthonta apo tou anthrōpou eisēlthon eis tous choirous). The paired 'from' (apo) and 'into' (eis) construction in the same sentence shows transfer of indwelling from one host to another, which only coheres if indwelling is the operative concept.

Acts.16.18 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1831 ἐξέρχομαι, G4436 πύθων

Force. Paul commands the spirit and 'it came out of her' (exelthen apo autēs) at the same hour. The slave girl is a pagan diviner with 'a python or divining spirit' (pneuma pythōna), and the 'from' (apo) plus genitive (the 'from/of' grammatical form) person construction mirrors the Gospel exorcism scenes. The vocabulary travels into Acts without change.

Acts.19.13 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2192 ἔχω, G4151 πνεῦμα

Force. Jewish exorcists name Jesus over 'those having the evil spirits' (tous echontas ta pneumata ta ponēra). The active participle (a verb acting like an adjective) of 'to have' (echō) for the relationship between the host and the spirit is a stock lexical idiom for being inhabited, parallel to 'having a demon' (ekhōn daimonion) in the Gospels.

Acts.19.16 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G4151 πνεῦμα

Force. 'The man in whom the evil spirit was' (ho anthrōpos en hō ēn to pneuma to ponēron) overpowers seven exorcists. The relative clause 'in whom' (en hō) locates the spirit inside the man, and 'having mastered them' (katakuriusas) shows the spirit acting through the unbelieving host with abnormal force.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Mark.5.7	Mark.1.24	tsk	1
Mark.5.15	Mark.5.4	tsk	1
Mark.5.8	Mark.9.25	tsk	1
Mark.5.13	Luke.8.33	tsk	1
Matt.12.22	Matt.12.43	tsk	1
Matt.12.45	Luke.11.26	openbible	2
Acts.16.16	Acts.16.18	tsk	1
Acts.19.15	Acts.16.17	tsk	1
Luke.8.2	Mark.16.9	openbible	2

Complicating texts

Luke.13.16 · addressed

The bent woman is called a daughter of Abraham whom Satan had 'bound' (edēsen) for eighteen years. The verb is 'to bind' (deō), not 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai), and the picture is external bondage rather than indwelling. So even a covenant member can be afflicted by Satan, but the specific lexical category of demonization with entering and exiting language is not applied here. The proposition about unbelievers being demonized is not threatened, because the verb under question is not used.

Luke.22.3 · addressed

Luke writes 'Satan entered into Judas' (eisēlthen Satanas eis Ioudan). This uses the exact 'enter into him' (eiserchomai eis auton) construction that elsewhere marks demonic inhabitation. Judas is one of the Twelve in outward affiliation, yet the narrative consistently presents him as not a true disciple, 'son of perdition' in John 17:12, 'devil' in John 6:70. So this verse uses the lexical inhabitation construction of an outward follower whom the canon does not number among true believers. It refines rather than contradicts the proposition, since it confirms that the entering language is reserved for those outside true discipleship.

Acts.5.3 · addressed

Peter says Satan 'filled' (eplēroō) the heart of Ananias, a member of the early church. The verb is 'to fill' (plēroō) plus 'the heart' (tēn kardia), not 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai) and not the 'enter into him' (eiserchomai eis auton) container construction. The lexical category here is influence on the heart, not indwelling of the person. The narrative does not portray Ananias as demonized in the 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai) sense, so it does not extend that category to believers.

Acts.16.16 · addressed

The slave girl has 'a python or divining spirit' (pneuma pythōna), and 'python' (pythōn) is a hapax legomenon (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the New Testament, occurring only here. Its single occurrence prevents independent lexical triangulation of the term itself, but the case is anchored by the surrounding inhabitation grammar in verse 18, 'to come out from her' (exelthein apo autēs), which uses the standard exorcism vocabulary. So the scene still counts as an unbeliever indwelt by a spirit that is expelled by command.

Concordance traversed

G1139, G1140, G0169, G1544, G1831, G1525, G2192, G0444, G4436, G4151, G1722, G1537

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units affecting the demonized condition were supplied or located. These passages fall outside the published scope of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants (ECM apparatus) for 3 John, so the manuscript picture is treated as 'ecm-shadow' (not directly covered by the published critical edition). The textual flags present in the SBLGNT (Society of Biblical Literature Greek New Testament) apparatus, such as Gerasenes versus Gadarenes versus Gergesenes in Mark 5:1 and Matthew 8:28, are geographic and do not affect the lexical pattern of indwelling and expulsion.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

lexical_minimalism: partial · Reading only the verb 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai) yields the bare claim that a person is demonized, without specifying the degree of indwelling. A minimalist reading affirms that unbelievers in the Gospels are demonized but withholds judgment on the parenthetical phrase 'full inhabitation', since the verb itself does not encode a degree.

narrative_syntactic: affirms · Attending to the syntax of indwelling, the 'in' (en) plus dative (the 'to/in/with' grammatical form) for the spirit's location in the man, the 'into' (eis) plus accusative (the direct-object grammatical form) for entering, the 'out of' (ek) and 'from' (apo) plus genitive (the 'from/of' grammatical form) for exiting, the first

person speech of the spirit through the man, and the superhuman strength in Acts 19:16, the narrative and grammar together describe inhabitation and operative control of unbelieving persons.

broad_demonic_affliction: affirms · Reading 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai) as a wide term that covers severe demonic affliction including but not limited to indwelling, the proposition still holds: unbelievers in the Gospels and Acts are repeatedly placed under demonic affliction that requires expulsion. The cases of Mark 9:25 and Luke 8:30 nevertheless add concrete entering and exiting grammar that goes beyond mere oppression.

The verdict turns on the spatial prepositions 'in' (en), 'into' (eis), 'out of' (ek), and 'from' (apo) combined with the verbs 'to enter' (eiserchomai), 'to come out' (exerchomai), and 'to throw or drive out' (ekballō), read across multiple Gospel and Acts scenes, with the principle of comparing Scripture with Scripture (analogia scripturae) confirming a consistent pattern across Mark, Matthew, Luke, and Acts.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Persons who are not disciples of Jesus are described in the Gospels and Acts as demonized, with spirits said to enter into them, dwell in them, speak through them, and be commanded out of them.

The parenthetical 'full inhabitation' in the stem preloads a degree term that the underlying verb 'to be demonized' (daimonizomai) does not lexically encode. The verb only states that a person is demonized. The degree of indwelling is inferred from the spatial prepositions and from the spirit speaking through the host and acting with its strength. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the affirmation rests on the lexically demonstrable indwelling and operative control of unbelieving persons, not on a precise quantification of inhabitation.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.5.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.9.25
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.8.30
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.12.43
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1139
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1140
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4436
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mark.5.8
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.18
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.8.33
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.16.16
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Matt.12.45

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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